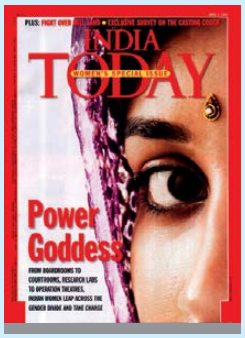
them in 1988, a gender focus we have kept up through the years. In the gallery of businesswomen this time, biotech superwoman Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw looms the largest, whose hunger for even greater glory is insatiable as she looks to take a global lead in biosimilars. There is also start-up success Falguni Nayar who, not content with a stellar career in investment banking, gave in to the urge to create "something that had a life of its own". That something was Nykaa, among the few female-led unicorns in the country.

Success, for some of these women, is not always about breaking the glass ceiling. "The elements of success are the same, whether you are a man or a woman," says Mallika Srinivasan, CMD of tractor giant TAFE.

There's also the "sari among the suits", Arundhati Bhattacharya, who after overseeing the tech transition at the State Bank of India as its first woman chairperson, now heads the India operations of global tech firm Salesforce. Other women achievers in business have had a headstart by virtue of being born into a legacy, like Apollo Hospitals MD Suneeta Reddy, HCL Technologies chairperson Roshni Nadar-Malhotra or RIL non-executive director Isha Ambani. But even being a billionaire's daughter will take you only so far, without the business savvy that built such wealth in the first place.

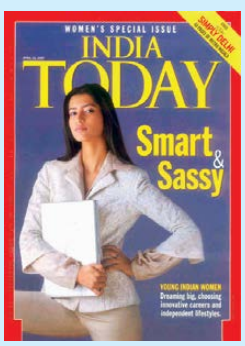
For corporate litigation doyenne Pallavi Shroff, being the daughter of a former chief justice (P.N. Bhagwati) and the wife of a scion (Shardul Shroff) of a leading law firm also meant carving a space for herself outside their giant shadows. "People would often ask me if I was waiting for my husband or senior lawyers to join me," she says. Riniki Bhuyan Sharma has to constantly fight criticism that her achievements are courtesy the fact her husband Himanta Biswa Sarma is the Assam chief minister. "I've inherited business skills from my father. I don't need political patronage to succeed," she says.



April 4, 2005



April 24, 2006



April 16, 2007



October 21, 2019

Each of their success is hard-won, and often at the cost of work-life balance. Shroff recalls how she would often have her children at the back of the courtroom in which she was arguing. Woman after woman emphasises the need for a support system. Even if you happen to be the chairperson of SEBI. "My mother-in-law was a big support for me," says Madhabi Puri Buch. "She was proud of me as a professional." Women often end up paying what is called "motherhood penalty", whereby their number in the workforce falls significantly as they marry or have children, showing the various challenges that disproportionately affect their career trajectories.

However, multi-tasking is a skill women acquire naturally. "All women are multi-taskers," says Nita Ambani, who is one herself. "I firmly believe what women cannot do, cannot be done." The women's voice remains important, whether in politics or in boardrooms. Aparna Purohit and Monika Shergill are bringing it to Prime Video and Netflix too. "One half the world is women, so why shouldn't we be represented equally, especially when telling stories?" asks Monika.

At the other end of the spectrum, we give you a Nikhat Zareen, 27, who came out of nowhere—or Nizamabad, which is close, when you consider the world of boxing and that of Muslim women. Her journey resembles a boxing match with life, where she has to win every round. With two world titles and a Commonwealth gold under her belt and the Olympics on her mind, she's not doing too bad. But the best bout she won was perhaps one in the mind. As she expressed it to INDIA TODAY: "I want to bust the stereotype that Muslim women should be in purdah." This uplifting tenor pervades the She List we have curated for you, with those from politics, sports and cinema who need no introduction standing on the same podium as the hidden figures of administration, science and defence. It's our privilege to celebrate our birthday by celebrating them.

(Aroon Purie)